

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 1/25: The clause, the one question, and the four layers

SYLLABUS CLAUSE (verbatim): "Religious Experience – Nature and Object (Indian and Western)."

CENTRAL QUESTION: what does an experience taken to be of the sacred establish, and for whom?

+-----+	+-----+	+-----+	+-----+
1 PHENOMEN- 2 CLAIMED 3 INTERPRET- 4 EPISTEMIC			
OLOGY OBJECT ATION FORCE			
what it is what seems how a what it			
like given tradition justifies,			
names it and for whom			
+-----+	+-----+	+-----+	+-----+

THREE ILLEGITIMATE JUMPS

A 1 -> 4 "it felt overwhelming, therefore it was veridical" (intensity is not warrant)

B 3 -> 2 "my tradition names it God, therefore God was met" (naming is not meeting)

C 4 <- x "it has a neural correlate, therefore it is nothing" (mediation is not fabrication)

THREE CAUTIONS: subjective = FIRST-PERSONAL, not unreal | ineffable = resists ADEQUATE expression, not contentless | neural correlate = MEDIATION, not disproof.

THREE DISTINCT ACHIEVEMENTS: psychological genuineness | doctrinal authenticity | metaphysical veridicality. Winning one does not win the others.

THE ONE RULE: every stem here has a NATURE half and an OBJECT half. Answer both, and say whether the object is ENCOUNTERED (relation) or REALISED (identity).

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 2/25: Why the clause exists, and the only datable anchors

ORIGIN PATH (conceptual, not calendar)

- 1 a subject reports an experience that seems to present a sacred or ultimate reality
- > 2 the report is FIRST-PERSONAL; its felt certainty is not transferable as it stands
- > 3 the subject's own tradition supplies the concepts that NAME what was met
- > 4 other traditions report INCOMPATIBLE objects with equal conviction
- > 5 a test is demanded, and every candidate test assesses AUTHENTICITY, not existence
- ==> the clause exists because stages 3, 4 and 5 cannot be waved away.

DATED PRINT ANCHORS (assert these years; invent no others)

1902 James, The Varieties of Religious Experience (Gifford Lectures 1901-02)
1912 Durkheim, The Elementary Forms of Religious Life 1917 Otto, The Idea of the Holy
1927 Radhakrishnan, The Hindu View of Life <== the NAMED work in the 2025 stem
1957 Zaehner, Mysticism Sacred and Profane 1957 Eliade, The Sacred and the Profane
1960 Stace, Mysticism and Philosophy 1971 Rachels, "God and Human Autonomy"
1978 Katz, "Language, Epistemology and Mysticism" 1979 Stump, "Petitionary Prayer"
1991 Alston, Perceiving God

CITE BY WORK, NEVER BY YEAR: Schleiermacher (The Christian Faith); Swinburne (The Existence of God); Hick (Philosophy of Religion); Forman (The Problem of Pure Consciousness); Aquinas (Summa Theologiae); Teresa of Avila (her criteria of discernment); Habermas (translation proviso); Brhadaranyaka Upanisad 1.4.10; Taittiriya Upanisad 2.4.1; the navadha bhakti list.

ANACHRONISM CONTROL: Otto (1917) answers James (1902); Stace (1960) answers Zaehner (1957); Katz (1978) answers the common core; Forman answers Katz. That order IS the argument.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 3/25: James I – the marks of mystical states, graded two-plus-two

DEFINING – these two define it

- (1) INEFFABILITY "defies expression"; must be DIRECTLY experienced; more like a feeling than a proposition; James calls it the "handiest" mark
- (2) NOETIC QUALITY "states of insight into depths of truth unplumbed by the discursive intellect"; carries a curious sense of AUTHORITY
= experienced insight, NOT independently demonstrated knowledge
----- USUAL – present in most cases -----
- (3) TRANSIENCY cannot be sustained long; may RECUR and DEVELOP on recurrence
- (4) PASSIVITY voluntary preliminaries may facilitate onset; once it sets in the mystic feels GRASPED AND HELD by a superior power

SCOPE: marks of MYSTICAL STATES, not of every religious experience.

AUTHORITY CLAUSE: authoritative for the one who has them; NO authority over outsiders.

==> this is the hinge of the veridicality question; James is not a proof of God.

WHY THE GRADING PAYS: transiency is only usual, so a STABLE, ESTABLISHED liberating knowledge (jnana) still counts as mystical. A flat four-mark list defines the Indian case out.

TRAP: the flat list of four equals is the single commonest error in this clause.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 4/25: James II – method, medical materialism, fruits, the "MORE"

METHOD: empirical (first-personal documents), pragmatic (responses), phenomenological, inductive

Religion is PERSONAL BEFORE INSTITUTIONAL; theology and church are secondary growths.

x REFUSED TEST – "MEDICAL MATERIALISM" (James's own term, Varieties, Lecture I)

discrediting a state by its physiological or pathological origin

REPLY: causal origin does not by itself settle truth or worth; the same argument would discredit every insight that arrived to a tired or unusual brain.

v ACCEPTED TEST – FRUITS: "by their fruits ye shall know them"

Matthew 7:16/20. James ADOPTS the maxim; he does NOT coin it. <== attribution matters
enduring moral integration, courage, charity, transformed conduct

THE OBJECT JAMES ALLOWS HIMSELF: the "MORE" – a wider reality with which the self feels
connected THROUGH THE SUBCONSCIOUS. Deliberately under-described, so the psychology does
not smuggle in a theology.

OBJECTION: a false belief that makes people kind would be vindicated by the fruits test.

REPLY: fruits are a criterion of AUTHENTICITY and VALUE, not a deductive proof of the object
– which is exactly why James cannot function as an argument for God's existence.

VERDICT SHAPE: strongest as phenomenology and pragmatic assessment; silent on the object.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 5/25: James III – the varieties (the second deliverable of 2022)

HEALTHY-MINDEDNESS	religion of the once-born; evil minimised, harmony affirmed	
THE SICK SOUL	acute consciousness of evil, guilt and finitude	
THE DIVIDED SELF	inner conflict seeking unification	
-> CONVERSION	the reorganisation of the divided self: orientation and conduct	
SAINTLINESS	the durable moral and affective FRUITS	
MYSTICISM	the experiential pole – the four marks of Panel 3	

+-----+

NOT A HIERARCHY: a map of how different TEMPERAMENTS meet the same problem. Preserving that plurality is what James's word "variety" actually names.

2022 STEM: "Discuss the nature and variety of religious experiences as presented by William James." NATURE = Panel 3 (graded marks). VARIETY = this panel. TWO DELIVERABLES.

PENALTY: a script that gives only the four marks has completed half the printed question.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 6/25: Otto – the anatomy of the numinous

THE HOLY (das Heilige) splits into

[A] NON-RATIONAL CORE = THE NUMINOUS

Otto's discovery

|

+-- MYSTERIUM ... wholly other; not merely unknown but INCOMMENSURABLE with ordinary
| categories

+-- TREMENDUM ... awefulness | overpoweringness (majestas) | energy and urgency

|

==> CREATURE-FEELING: one's own nothingness before the incommensurable

+-- FASCINANS ... it attracts, entrances and beatifies EVEN WHILE it terrifies
dread and longing in ONE state, in ONE subject, at once

LATIN, WRITTEN IN FULL ONCE: mysterium tremendum et fascinans (Otto's own Latin, 1917).

IT IS NOT: fear of a danger (a danger is a comparable thing), nor an intensified moral awe.

PRESUPPOSITION, STATED HONESTLY: that the phenomenological distinctiveness of awe supports a
distinctive OBJECT rather than merely an unusual emotion. That is what the critic denies.

[B] RATIONAL / MORAL SCHEMATISATION

goodness, justice, purpose, personality

added LATER, not first

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 7/25: Otto – non-rational, Schleiermacher, and the cross-cultural limit

*** NON-RATIONAL is NOT IRRATIONAL ***

non-rational = not reducible to conceptual and moral judgement (Otto CLAIMS this)

irrational = contradicting reason (Otto DENIES this)

moral and rational predicates are retained as LATER SCHEMATISATIONS of a prior datum

SCHLEIERMACHER, for contrast (The Christian Faith)

essence of religion = the FEELING OF ABSOLUTE DEPENDENCE

Otto's implicit correction: dependence is a feeling ABOUT MYSELF; the numinous is

constituted by DIRECTEDNESS TO A WHOLLY OTHER – it has an object-pole built in.

OBJECTION: psychology can explain awe – evolutionarily, socially, neurologically – without any numinous object; Otto has reified a culturally trained emotion.

REPLY: he describes the INTENTIONAL STRUCTURE of the state, and intentionality is a form, not an extra feeling. Fear-of-a-tiger is not tiger-flavoured anxiety; it is directed.

BOUNDED: describing a state as object-directed does not show the object exists. Say both halves.

CROSS-CULTURAL LIMIT: Indian traditions often organise the sacred through PURITY and

AUSPICIOUSNESS (pavitra, suddha, mangala), not through dread. A real limit on Otto's claim.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 8/25: Stace – two types, five shared marks, one common core

EXTROVERTIVE: the underlying vision is achieved THROUGH the physical senses; the mystic still

sees the multiplicity of objects but perceives the ONE SHINING THROUGH them,
with an apprehension of an inner subjectivity or life in all things

INTROVERTIVE ALL sensory and conceptual content is EXCLUDED, leaving a unitary, CONTENTLESS
pure consciousness – non-spatial, non-temporal.

Stace regards this as the HIGHER and more complete type.

FIVE SHARED MARKS (reported WITHIN the descriptions, not imposed afterwards)

sense of objectivity or reality | blessedness and peace | feeling of the holy or sacred |
paradoxicality | ineffability

THE DECISIVE METHODOLOGICAL MOVE

separate the EXPERIENCE ITSELF from its INTERPRETATION

-> the experiences converge cross-culturally; the interpretations (theistic, monistic,
Buddhist) diverge ==> the classic PERENNIALIST / COMMON-CORE thesis

OBJECTION: "interpretation" is doing all the work – subtract enough of it from any two
experiences and they will look alike.

REPLY: the five marks are reported inside the descriptions; the claim then narrows from
"identical core" to "recurrent reported marks" – weaker, and more defensible.

ANCHOR: W. T. Stace, Mysticism and Philosophy, 1960.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 9/25: Zaehner – three types, no common core, and a contested ranking

(1) NATURE MYSTICISM (pan-en-theos, "all in one")

a sense of oneness with nature; Zaehner controversially groups certain DRUG-INDUCED states here, IN EXPLICIT OPPOSITION to Aldous Huxley's claims for mescaline

(2) MONISTIC MYSTICISM

isolation or identity of the soul with an IMPERSONAL absolute

– Samkhya-Yoga's aloneness (kaivalya); Advaita's non-dual realisation

(3) THEISTIC MYSTICISM

loving union with a PERSONAL God in which the creature/creator distinction is PRESERVED

– Ramanuja, Sufism, Christian mysticism

!! ZAEHNER RANKS THEM, theistic highest. Widely criticised as CONFESSIONALLY MOTIVATED

(he was a Catholic convert). State the criticism – and state what survives it.

WHAT SURVIVES: monistic and theistic reports differ in LOGICAL FORM.

IDENTITY abolishes one term; RELATION requires two. A common-core theory must EXPLAIN that away, not assume it.

EXAM MOVE: KEEP the classification, DROP the ranking.

STACE vs ZAEHNER ARE RIVALS, NOT COMPLEMENTS: 2 types + a core, against 3 types + no core.

ANCHOR: R. C. Zaehner, *Mysticism Sacred and Profane*, 1957.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 10/25: Mediation – Katz, Forman, attribution and plural mediation

POSITION	CLAIM	PRESSURE ON IT
PERENNIAL CORE (Stace)	traditions interpret a substantially shared core	subtracting "interpretation" may manufacture an abstract sameness
CONSTRUCTIVISM (Katz 1978)	concepts, expectations and practices shape the EXPERIENCE itself	contentless or minimally conceptual states pressure the universal claim
ATTRIBUTION (Proudfoot-style)	an experience is religious partly because the subject explains it religiously	explaining CLASSIFICATION may not exhaust phenomenology or object
PLURAL MEDIATION (Hick)	diverse traditions are culturally conditioned responses to ONE Real	an unknowable Real may be too indeterminate to support specific claims

KATZ'S THESIS, EXACTLY: "there are no unmediated experiences". A Jewish mystic does not have a Buddhist experience differently described; they have DIFFERENT EXPERIENCES.

FORMAN'S REPLY: the PURE CONSCIOUSNESS EVENT – a contentless state has nothing for concepts to shape, so the thesis fails at the introvertive limit Stace called the higher type.

HONEST VERDICT: constructivism is STRONG for extrovertive and theistic reports, WEAKEST for the contentless case – which is exactly where its opponents concentrate.

WHAT IT DEFEATS: the CONVERGENCE INFERENCE, not the occurrence. Mediated perception is still perception; separate OCCURRENCE, INTERPRETATION and VERIDICALITY and argue each on its own.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 11/25: Advaita – six features, each against its rival

FEATURE	CONTRASTED WITH
-----+-----	
1 NON-DUAL (nirvikalpa): subject-object duality collapses	theistic mysticism: an encounter between two terms that both remain
2 IDENTITY, not relation: "I am Brahman" (aham brahmasmi, Brhadaranyaka Up.1.4.10)	Otto's "wholly other"; Ramanuja's loving union which PRESERVES the creature-creator distinction
3 SELF-ESTABLISHED (svatah-siddha): self-luminous consciousness is not established by a further cognition	James's noetic mark, which is FELT authority; Alston's prima facie, defeasible warrant
4 BEYOND OBJECTIFYING SPEECH (avacya): "from which words turn back" (yato vaco nivartante)	ineffability as a mere reporting difficulty; here it is a claim about the STRUCTURE of what is realised
5 BLISS (ananda), beyond the categories of ordinary cognition	emotional ecstasy; ananda is ontological, not a mood
6 STABLE KNOWLEDGE (jnana), not an episode	James's TRANSIENCY – which is why his grading of the marks matters for the comparison
ARGUMENT: subject-object cognition presupposes a WITNESSING consciousness that is never itself an object; scripture (sruti) removes false identification; inquiry ends in recognition.	
OBJECTION: a contentless experience cannot identify Brahman.	
REPLY: Brahman is SELF, not inferred object; instruction PREPARES a non-objective recognition.	
PRICE (name it): the state leaves the space of ordinary evidence, so it cannot be re-entered as public evidence for Brahman. That is what the diversity objection exploits.	

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 12/25: Advaita – the route, the image, and the terminological firewall

THE ROUTE

hearing (sravana) -> reflection (manana) -> contemplation (nididhyasana) -> realisation
instruction PREPARES and REMOVES; it does not manufacture an object.

THE IMAGE – THE TENTH MAN

nine men count the party and each forgets to count himself; they grieve for a man who was
never lost. Instruction removes IGNORANCE OF AN ALREADY PRESENT FACT.

This is the exact model of how sruti is supposed to work: removal, not production.

STABILITY OVER ECSTASY

it is not a temporary altered state alone; stable knowledge (jnana) matters more than
episodic ecstasy. Assessment is SOTERIOLOGICAL: does it remove ignorance and bondage?

>>> TERMINOLOGICAL FIREWALL <<<

do NOT call this experience anirvacaniya.

In Advaita's technical vocabulary anirvacaniya = "indescribable as either real or unreal"
(sad-asad-vilaksana) and is the status of MAYA and the WORLD-APPEARANCE – never of Brahman
or of Brahman-realisation. A 2025 Religious Language question prints anirvacaniyata in its
own proper sense; importing it here is a scripted error.

OTHER TRAPS: do not write "a subject perceiving Brahman as object"; do not translate ananda
as "happiness" or "ecstasy".

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 13/25: Radhakrishnan – the inversion, three claims, three pressures

ORDINARY PICTURE

RADHAKRISHNAN'S INVERSION (The Hindu View of Life, 1927)

creed -> practice -> experience
as confirmation

EXPERIENCE (anubhava): INTEGRAL INTUITION uniting
cognition, feeling and will; higher than sense and
reason because it does not divide subject from object

|

- v INTERPRETATION by a tradition (concepts, symbols)
- v CREED . RITUAL . INSTITUTION = "secondary"
- v TOLERANCE follows as a CONSEQUENCE: rival creeds
are rival readings of a depth none of them owns

THREE CLAIMS TO NAME

- (1) experience is PRIMARY
- (2) it is SELF-CERTIFYING
- (3) it is UNIVERSAL across
traditions

THREE PRESSURES TO STATE

- (1) prior to all creeds = correctable by none
- (2) self-certification is what an outsider cannot check
- (3) "one depth, many readings" is itself a substantive
metaphysics -> the ADVAITIC ASSIMILATION charge

DISTINCTION THAT PROTECTS HIM: his "intuition" is NOT a hunch – it is claimed as disciplined,
integral and transformative awareness, the product of a practice.

PRESUPPOSITION: that intuition DISCLOSES REALITY rather than reporting subjective intensity.

REPLY TO THE CHARGE: universality concerns experiential DEPTH, not identical doctrinal
description – and the adequacy of that reply REMAINS CONTESTED. Report the contest.

2025 STEM DISCIPLINE: name the WORK'S OWN THESES first; evaluate second.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 14/25: Vedantic plurality – the 2021 stem says "tradition", not "Advaita"

SANKARA (Advaita) highest realization – NON-OBJECTIVE RECOGNITION OF IDENTITY;
subject-object duality belongs to ignorance; Brahman is self-luminous
consciousness presupposed by every act of knowing

RAMANUJA (Visistadvaita) rejects the erasure of difference: Brahman is PERSONAL; selves and
world are REAL MODES dependent on God; fulfilment is loving knowledge
and communion in which the worshipper is NOT dissolved

MADHVA (Dvaita) hardens the distinction: God and soul remain ETERNALLY DIFFERENT;
saving experience is a GRACE-ENABLED RELATION

==> Vedanta contains BOTH identity-recognition AND intentional encounter. A script that
reduces "the Vedantic tradition" to Advaita has misread the printed word.

EPISTEMIC STATUS VARIES WITH THE SCHOOL

Advaita: self-certifying, because self-luminous consciousness needs no second cognition

Devotional schools: greater weight on scripture, grace and the transformed relation

COMMON TEST ACROSS ALL SCHOOLS: SOTERIOLOGICAL – does it remove ignorance, egoism, bondage?

That is what distinguishes Vedantic anubhava from an unregulated private impression.

OBJECTION: incompatible structures suggest doctrine imposed on ambiguous states.

REPLY: concede MEDIATION, deny FABRICATION. Each school supplies practice, grammar and tests
of transformation – but those criteria are INTERNAL, and internal criteria do not prove the
metaphysical object to an outsider.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 15/25: The Indian experience-types bridge – four structures

TRADITION	EXPERIENCE-STRUCTURE	TERMINUS	CONTROL
ADVAITA	non-dual recognition through hearing, reflection, contemplation	the self AS Brahman	NOT an encounter between two independently existing terms
YOGA	disciplined concentration culminating in seedless absorption and discriminative freedom	isolated consciousness (purusa)	Yoga's special Lord is NOT the creator-object of every experience
DEVOTIONAL (bhakti)	love, surrender, remembrance, prayer and worship	a personal Lord	relation and grace remain REAL – do not redescribe as Advaitic identity
BUDDHISM	meditative insight into impermanence, no-permanent-self and conditioned arising	Dharma / cessation (nirvana) NOT a creator God	noetic and transformative claims remain tradition- mediated; "object" may mislead

FOUR LOGICAL FORMS: identity | isolation | relation | insight.

THE MARKS ARE IN THE CONTROLS: each blocks a specific misreading – dualising Advaita, theologising Yoga, Advaitising devotion, theologising Buddhism.

PRESSURE ON THE TYPOLOGIES: Zaehner's monistic/theistic pair has no comfortable slot for Buddhist insight; Stace's introvertive type must treat each tradition's own account of its terminus as mere interpretation – which is exactly Katz's objection.

BRIDGE ONLY: meditation stages and liberation doctrine remain with the Paper I owners.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 16/25: The object – sacred, holy, God (2018 Q7(a), 20 marks)

EXACT STEP: "The terms 'Sacred' and 'Holy' have come to serve as generic names for the object

of religion. Do you agree that one can have God as the object of religion? Discuss."

==> it GRANTS the generic category and asks about the SPECIFIC one. Answer in DEGREES.

WHY 'SACRED/HOLY' BECAME GENERIC

- (1) OTTO the HOLY names a quality of the object disclosed in numinous awe, PRIOR to and independent of moral and rational predicates -> more basic than "God"
- (2) DURKHEIM (1912) the SACRED defined RELATIONALLY, by separation from the profane and by the prohibitions that protect it -> needs no deity; covers totemic religion
- (3) ELIADE (1957) HIEROPHANY: the sacred manifests and structures sacred space and time
- (4) DECISIVE non-theistic religions have a sacred but NO God: nirvana and the Dharma; the Tirthankara and the siddha; the authorless (apauruseya) Veda; the Tao

THE GRADED ANSWER

YES for theistic traditions – classical theism, Visistadvaita, Saiva Siddhanta, Islam, Judaism – where God is not one sacred item but the SOURCE AND MEASURE of holiness

NO as a generic definition – that would stipulate Buddhism, Jainism and Mimamsa out of religion. ==> 'SACRED' IS THE GENUS; GOD IS THEISM'S SPECIES OF IT.

DISCRIMINATOR THAT EARNS MARKS: Otto's HOLY is NOT Durkheim's SACRED. Phenomenological quality of an object vs social classification. Treating them as one word misses the strongest objection to each.

INDIAN PARITY: pavitra/suddha, mangala, punya, tirtha, ksetra, devalaya; parvan days, muhurta, the ritual calendar; the Veda's sanctity as apauruseya – SANCTITY WITHOUT A SANCTIFIER.

OBJ 1 over-breadth (flags, nations) -> REPLY add the SOTERIOLOGICAL requirement

OBJ 2 God subordinated to a genus -> REPLY the subordination is CONCEPTUAL, not ontological

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 17/25: Veridicality – the warrant ledger and the burden clause

FOR VERIDICALITY

CREDULITY (Swinburne): if it SEEMS to S that X is present, probably X is – absent defeaters

TESTIMONY: others' reports are probably as reported – extends warrant to the HEARER

NOETIC QUALITY: the state presents itself as disclosure, not as imagination

CONVERGENCE: mystics across traditions report recurrent marks

AGAINST – DEFEATERS

(a) NATURALISTIC EXPLANATION: Freud's projection and wish-fulfilment; social and psychological formation; neural mediation

>>> BURDEN: the critic must show the mechanism is UNRELIABLE, or that it FULLY explains the seeming WITHOUT the proposed object. A correlation alone is not a defeat. <<<

(b) UNRELIABLE CONDITIONS: drugs, pathology, suggestion, deprivation

(c) DIVERSITY <== THE SERIOUS ONE: personal God / non-dual Brahman / emptiness reported with equal conviction. Which object is real?

FOUR CRITICISMS AND THEIR REPLIES

naturalism -> origin does not by itself falsify content; defeaters must show unreliability

conflicting -> interpretation may vary while contact is common

objects REJOINER: this reply can become UNFALSIFIABLE

ineffability -> limits exhaustiveness, not every statement; analogical report survives

moral fruits -> a criterion of AUTHENTICITY, not a deductive proof of the object

RANKING (this is what earns the top band): naturalism is the LOUDEST and WEAKEST defeater;

diversity is the QUIETEST and STRONGEST, because it needs only incompatibility.

BALANCE TO WRITE: prima facie warrant for the SUBJECT + testimonial weight for the HEARER

- public demonstration of the OBJECT. "Causal explanation and epistemic defeat differ."

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 18/25: Alston – six steps, the exact conclusion, and the concession

- (1) THEOREY OF APPEARING: perception is a form of appearing, and appearing is not essential to that structure, so a non-sensory presentation can still be perception
- (2) MYSTICAL PERCEPTION SHARES THE STRUCTURE: apparent object + mode of presentation + resulting belief ==> M-BELIEFS (from mystical perception)
- (3) BELIEFS ARE FORMED WITHIN DOXASTIC PRACTICES: socially established, internally organised, with their own inputs, outputs and OVERRIDE procedures
- (4) NO DOXASTIC PRACTICE CAN BE SHOWN RELIABLE WITHOUT CIRCULARITY: sense perception cannot be validated except by using sense perception; likewise memory and induction
- (5) WE ARE NONETHELESS PRACTICALLY RATIONAL in engaging in sense perception
- (6) THEREFORE engagement in an established religious practice (Christian Mystical Practice, CMP) is PRACTICALLY RATIONAL, absent sufficient reason to think it unreliable
- CLAIMED: prima facie justification for M-beliefs; PRACTICAL RATIONALITY of engagement
- NOT CLAIMED: proof that the practice is reliable; ultima facie justification
- >>> "Alston proved religious experience reliable" is the standard overstatement. <<<
- ILLUSTRATION: a novice cannot show sense perception reliable without already relying on it; the demand for non-circular validation, uniformly applied, destroys ALL our practices.
- DIVERSITY OBJECTION – WHICH ALSTON HIMSELF CALLS THE MOST SERIOUS: CMP, Buddhist, Advaitic and Islamic practices are each established and self-supporting; if that makes engagement rational, it makes engagement in INCOMPATIBLE practices rational.
- HIS ANSWER: it is rational to "SIT TIGHT" absent a neutral adjudicating ground – conceding the discomfort and that a better argument might overturn it. An honest answer stops there.
- SECOND OBJECTION: no cross-checking, prediction or intersubjective agreement.
- REPLY: CMP has internal OVERRIDE SYSTEMS – discernment criteria, doctrinal tests, spiritual direction – weaker than science's, but not absent.
- DISTINGUISH FROM SWINBURNE: credulity is about SEEMINGS; Alston's argument is about PRACTICES.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 19/25: Diversity – the defeater, the three exits, and the price

the DATA: personal God (religion) | non-dual Brahman (identity) | emptiness and cessation
(no such term) | isolated consciousness (withdrawal) – all reported with equal conviction
THE DEFEATER: apply the principle of credulity EVENLY and it licenses INCOMPATIBLE conclusions.
So either the principle is restricted (on what principled ground?) or some seemings are
non-veridical (which ones, and by what test?).
EXIT 1 HICK – PLURAL MEDIATION: one Real an sich, experienced through culturally conditioned
lenses. PRICE: a Real beyond all determinate description cannot ground the
DETERMINATE claims traditions make; and the reply can become UNFALSIFIABLE.
EXIT 2 EXCLUSIVISM: one is right, the rest mistaken. Bites the bullet; owes an account of the
others' sincerity, discipline and fruits.
EXIT 3 CONSTRUCTIVISM (Katz): they are DIFFERENT EXPERIENCES, not one differently described.
THE THREE-WAY SPLIT THAT SCORES
Did something occur? diversity is SILENT; the reports stand
How was it interpreted? diversity is DECISIVE; interpretation is tradition-relative
Was it veridical? diversity is a GENUINE DEFEATER; incompatible objects cannot all
be met
OBJECTION: diversity would equally defeat ordinary perception, where observers also disagree.
REPLY: the disanalogy is PROCEDURAL. Perceivers can move closer, measure, repeat, ask a third
party. Religious practices have INTERNAL override systems but no CROSS-PRACTICE adjudicating
procedure. Nothing in the practice is designed to settle disagreement ACROSS practices.
SAFE RESIDUE: claim FAMILY RESEMBLANCE or ANALOGOUS TRANSFORMATION, not identity of content.
BOUNDARY: complete pluralist theory belongs to the Religious Pluralism owner.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 20/25: Mystical experience and revelation (2023 Q8(c), 15 marks)

	REVELATION CLAIMED	NO REVELATION CLAIMED
MYSTICAL STATE PRESENT	(1) VEHICLE CASE: the state is received AS disclosure of the Real; Hick's non-propositional model; "experiencing-as"	(2) PURE EXPERIENCE CASE: a unitive or numinous state reported with NO claim to disclose a message or a will
NO MYSTICAL STATE	(3) PROPOSITIONAL CASE: truths delivered through prophet, text or tradition, with no unitive state involved	(4) NEITHER

CELLS (2) AND (3) PROVE NON-IDENTITY. If mystical experience WERE revelation, (2) would be impossible; if revelation WERE mystical experience, (3) would be impossible. Both occur.

RELATION: VEHICLE to CARGO. The state can CARRY a disclosure without BEING one.

SIGNIFICANCE IN RELIGIOUS LIFE (the second printed deliverable) – three functions

ORIGIN founders' disclosures generate traditions and supply their normative content

RENEWAL later mystics re-authenticate the tradition from within

RISK an unchecked private disclosure can override community, scripture and moral judgement ==> hence DISCERNMENT (Teresa's criteria; the guru's testing)

INDIAN PARALLEL, BOUNDED: sruti removes ignorance while realisation is the cognitive event – instruction to insight, not message to messenger.

OBJECTION: if revelation is what the receiver takes the event to be, disclosure collapses into projection. REPLY: the distinction is preserved by DISCERNMENT, not by phenomenology – and discernment tests AUTHENTICITY, not truth.

BOUNDARY: faith's RECEPTION of revelation belongs to the Reason, Revelation and Faith owner.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 21/25: Prayer and worship (2020 Q7(b), 15 marks)

AXIS	PRAYER	WORSHIP
Essential act	ADDRESS / communication	ASCRPTION OF SUPREME WORTH (homage)
Direction	person-to-person (I-Thou)	creature-before-the-holy
Form	verbal or silent; spontaneous	ritual, embodied, rule-governed
Locus	often private	characteristically corporate
Presupposes	a God who can HEAR and RESPOND	a reality of supreme value; RESPONSE NOT REQUIRED
Non-theistic avail.	strained	available

OVERLAP: ADORATION – address (prayer) AND ascription of worth (worship).

LIMIT CASE: wordless contemplative prayer – address persists after request disappears.

KINDS OF PRAYER: A-C-T-S = Adoration, Confession, Thanksgiving, Supplication (+ intercession, contemplative prayer).

PROBLEM 1 – PETITION: omniscient (already knows) + perfectly good (will already do the best) + immutable (cannot be changed) ==> petition is idle or manipulative.

AQUINAS: we pray to OBTAIN WHAT GOD HAS DETERMINED SHALL BE OBTAINED THROUGH PRAYER – a genuine SECONDARY CAUSE inside the causal order, not an override of the primary one.

STUMP (1979): asking PROTECTS THE RELATIONSHIP; unrequested benefaction from an overwhelming superior risks spoiling the recipient. RESIDUE: justifies petition's VALUE, not that outcomes causally depend on it.

PROBLEM 2 – WORSHIP AND AUTONOMY, RACHELS (1971): worship entails unconditional obedience; moral agency forbids abdicating final judgement; so nothing could be WORTHY OF WORSHIP.

REPLIES: worship recognises WORTH, not blind obedience | a perfectly good being's commands coincide with moral judgement | the autonomy assumed is atomistic.

THREE INDIAN CASES THAT DECIDE IT

JAINISM the Tirthankara is free of passion (vitaraga) and CANNOT RESPOND; image-veneration (caitya-vandana) = worship without any possibility of petition being answered

MIMAMSA efficacy lies in the unseen potency (apurva); the deity is a GRAMMATICAL DATIVE in the injunction, not an agent who grants

ADVAITA contemplative worship (upasana) of a qualified form is efficacious at the everyday level (vyavaharika) and is TRANSCENDED, not repudiated, at the ultimate level

BUDDHISM ritual honour (puja) is commemorative and dispositional (Pure Land complicates it)

PLACEMENT: prayer = RELATIONAL organ; worship = EVALUATIVE and COMMUNAL organ.

A religion can survive the loss of petition; NONE survives the loss of worship, because nothing would then mark the ultimate as ultimate.

VERDICT FORMULA: prayer presupposes a RESPONSIVE ultimate; worship presupposes only a SUPREMELY VALUABLE one.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 22/25: Public discourse (2019 Q7(c), 15 marks) – the ladder and the line

public discourse?" ==> a DEGREE is required, never a yes/no.

CASE FOR NO

- (1) INEFFABILITY resists the articulation discourse requires
- (2) PRIVILEGED ACCESS – James concedes authority only for the one who has the state
- (3) NO SHARED CHECKING PROCEDURE, unlike perception
- (4) WITTGENSTEIN's private-language considerations: a wholly private criterion is none
- (5) RAWLSIAN PUBLIC REASON: for coercive decisions, offer reasons others could accept

CASE FOR YES – SIX INTERSUBJECTIVE CRITERIA (ascending publicity)

- (1) PHENOMENOLOGICAL DESCRIPTION – James, Otto, Stace, Zaehner built public typologies out of first-person documents: PUBLIC WORK ON PRIVATE DATA. Even ineffability is reportable.
- (2) COHERENCE – internally consistent, and consistent with what is otherwise known
- (3) DISCERNMENT NORMS – Teresa of Avila's criteria; the guru's verification; the acarya's testing
- (4) MORAL AND PRACTICAL FRUITS – transformation of conduct is OBSERVABLE
- (5) REPLICABILITY THROUGH DISCIPLINED PRACTICE – yoga, dhyana, nididhyasana: repeatable procedures with stated preconditions and predicted outcomes. Vivekananda and Radhakrishnan press this as an "experimental" CLAIM.
LIMIT: the experiment cannot be run by an uncommitted observer -> closer to the training-dependence of EXPERT PERCEPTION than to a public laboratory test.
- (6) ALSTON'S DOXASTIC PRACTICES – legitimate topic of PUBLIC ARGUMENT ABOUT PRACTICES, if not of public verification of episodes

===== THE LINE =====

All six are publicly assessable and test AUTHENTICITY. None transfers the EVIDENTIAL FORCE the experience has for its subject. CONCEDE THIS EXPLICITLY – the concession earns marks.

=====

BRIDGE – HABERMAS: religious citizens may speak religiously in the INFORMAL public sphere, subject to an institutional TRANSLATION PROVISIO before formal state decision-making.

==> the "how far" gets a determinate answer: FULLY in the informal sphere, CONDITIONALLY in the formal one.

VERDICT: publicly DISCUSSABLE and privately PROBATIVE – not publicly demonstrative.

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 23/25: The parity bench and the ten-row risk column

AXIS	WESTERN	INDIAN	DISCRIMINATING POINT
STRUCTURE	encounter/union with an Other (Otto, theistic mysticism)	IDENTITY-recognition (Advaita) or ISOLATION (Samkhya-Yoga)	relation vs identity is a LOGICAL, not a stylistic difference
DURATION	transient (usual mark)	jnana is STABLE and ESTABLISHED	why James's GRADING of the marks matters
METHOD	grace, contemplation, sacrament	disciplined, staged, repeatable	India's REPLICABILITY claim in the 2019 question
AUTHORITY	for the SUBJECT only (James)	svatah-siddha, but tested by guru and sruti	both restrict transfer; India adds discernment
OBJECT-TERM	God, the Holy, the numinous	Brahman, purusa, nirvana, the Tirthankara	the generic term must be "SACRED", not "God"
RITUAL	prayer, sacrament,	upasana, puja, japa,	Jain and Mimamsa worship
CORRELATE	liturgy	dhyana	WITHOUT a responsive deity
TEN ACCOUNTS AND THEIR CHARACTERISTIC RISK (the risk column IS the assessment)			
James	mystical, transformative	the "MORE"	RISK subjectivism
Otto	numinous awe	Holy/wholly other	RISK reification of emotion
Schleiermacher	feeling of dependence	the Infinite	RISK subject-centred account
Stace	extrovertive/introvertive	the One	RISK interpretation does all work
Zaehner	nature/monistic/theistic	three objects	RISK confessional ranking
Alston	perceptual (M-perception)	God, presented	RISK diversity of practices
Advaita	non-dual recognition	Brahman as self	RISK content/criterion problem
Radhakrishnan	integral intuition	the Spirit/Real	RISK Advaitic assimilation
Theistic myst.	union/communion	personal God	RISK conflict with non-dual reports
Buddhism	insight/awakening	nirvana, no creator	RISK "object" category misleads
Durkheim/Eliade	socially structured	the SACRED	RISK over-breadth
RULE: match ONE axis to the stem and run it to its discriminating point. One axis used precisely beats six axes listed.			

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 24/25: PYQ routing and the directive decoder

THE CLAUSE OWNS EXACTLY ONE PART IN EVERY PAPER, 2018-2025 (8 of 112 parts overall)

- 2018 Q7(a) 20m 'Sacred' and 'Holy' as generic names; can one have God as the object?
- 2019 Q7(c) 15m How far can religious experience be made a topic of public discourse?
- 2020 Q7(b) 15m Distinguish prayer and worship and determine their place in religion.
- 2021 Q7(c) 15m Religious experience in the light of the Vedantic tradition.
- 2022 Q7(c) 15m Nature and variety of religious experiences as presented by William James.
- 2023 Q8(c) 15m Relation between mystical experience and revelation, and their significance.
- 2024 Q8(c) 15m Main features of religious experience according to Advaita Vedanta.
- 2025 Q8(a) 20m Nature and object of Religious Experience per Radhakrishnan, The Hindu View of Life.

DIRECTIVES AND WHAT EACH BUYS

- | | |
|-------------------------------------|--|
| "Do you agree...? Discuss" | -> a graded position on the PRINTED proposition |
| "How far...? Analyse" | -> a DEGREE, and the exact line you draw |
| "Distinguish A and B and determine" | -> TWO deliverables; half on each |
| "in the light of [tradition]" | -> tradition-internal categories, and its INTERNAL plurality |
| "nature and variety ... [thinker]" | -> the graded MARKS and the TYPOLOGY |
| "Examine the relation ... expound" | -> relation FIRST, then significance |
| "main features of X" | -> an enumerated list, each feature with a discriminator |
| "Evaluate ... in [named work]" | -> the work's own theses first, assessment second |

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 25/25: Architectures, verdict ladder and the answer spine

ARCHITECTURES

10m define -> structured marks -> object -> ONE objection -> limited verdict
15m nature/object -> account and presupposition -> canonical example -> Indian/Western
contrast -> veridicality objection and reply
20m phenomenology -> claimed object -> warrant (credulity/testimony/fruits) -> naturalistic
AND diversity defeaters -> Indian-Western comparison -> graded verdict + THE DEFEATER
THAT WOULD CHANGE IT

VERDICT LADDER

Weak ~40% flat four marks; Otto mentioned; no object-analysis, no veridicality question
Avg ~50% marks + numinous + Advaita, correct terms, but marks ungraded
Good ~60% nature/object separated; one epistemic objection raised
Strong ~65-70% graded marks; identity-vs-relation; credulity and defeaters; Indian parity
Top ~70%+ + a discriminating distinction (defining vs usual | Otto's holy != Durkheim's
sacred | constructivism vs the Pure Consciousness Event | prima facie vs ultima
facie) + a statement of the defeater that would change the verdict

THE ANSWER SPINE

name the LAYER -> define the experience -> state the account with its DECISIVE discrimination
-> identify the CLAIMED OBJECT and say encountered or realised -> apply credulity, testimony
and the defeaters -> run ONE Indian-Western axis to its discriminating point -> strongest
objection, named -> reply -> GRADED VERDICT + the defeater that would overturn it.

CLOSE: religious experience confers prima facie, defeasible justification on the subject and
testimonial weight on the hearer; it does not establish its object publicly. Diversity, not
neurology, is the serious defeater – causal explanation and epistemic defeat are different
things.